

GR8 GOING
Customers at the GR8 retail store in Halmulla



"NOW WHEN WE HAVE GLOBAL RECOGNITION AND THE DEMAND FOR OUR BATS HAS INCREASED, WE ARE FACING A SHORTAGE OF WILLOW.... FOR A CENTURY, WE CUT THE WILLOW, BUT DID NOT PLANT NEW ONES"

FAYAZ AHMAD DAR, *president, Cricket Bat Manufacturing Association, Kashmir*

bats has increased by 16 per cent," he says. "Now when we are getting recognition, we are facing a shortage of willow. For a century, we cut down the willow, but did not plant new ones. We will be jobless in five years if the government does not start a sustainable plantation drive," he adds.

A World Bank-funded study by SKUAST in collaboration with the state's industries department in 2022 says 95 per cent of the willow variants in Kashmir cannot be used to make quality bats. "Right now, only five per cent of the population of female willows can be used to make cricket bats," says Dr Parvez Ahmad Sofi, professor and head, Forest Products and Utilisation, and principal investigator of the Willow Project at SKUAST. The varsity has now distributed lab-produced saplings to farmers and bat manufacturers. "But it will take at least a decade to end the shortfall. We have distributed 15,000 trees, they'll have to cut the branches, use it for propagation," says Sofi.

The government too is doing its bit. In 2019, the cluster of villages making bats in south Kashmir (from Sangam to Bijbehara) was declared an industry, thus entitling it to many state benefits. Industries and commerce department director Mehmood Ahmad Shah agrees that the bat industry needs massive technological intervention to produce quality cricket bats that can compete with the English willow. The state is now also trying to get GI tagging for Kashmiri bats and has submitted a dossier on this to the concerned authorities in Chennai. "Our bats are not able to fetch good prices compared to English willow because of many reasons, including the fact that they are heavier," he says. ICC specification Kashmir willow bats cost around Rs 10,000 now as against Rs 1.25 lakh for English willow bats. "We are setting up a seasoning plant specifically for willow so as to provide all facilities to the bat manufacturers under one roof," he adds. That may not be enough if the crisis in quality willow continues. ■